

Classic Chicago Magazine

Writer's Guide

1. About Classic Chicago Magazine

Classic Chicago Magazine is a weekly digital publication celebrating Chicago culture, dining, arts, society, and the people who make the city extraordinary. We publish every Sunday as "The Sunday Edition."

Our readers are engaged, curious Chicagoans who love the city's cultural life — from gallery openings and theater reviews to neighborhood dining and community stories. We aim to be elegant, warm, and substantive.

2. Writing Standards

Voice and Tone

Write with warmth, authority, and a sense of occasion. Classic Chicago is not a newspaper — we are a magazine with a personality. Avoid dry or purely informational prose. Bring the reader into the scene.

- Write in the first or third person as appropriate to the piece.
- Avoid jargon and overly academic language.
- Spell out numbers one through nine; use numerals for 10 and above.
- Use the Oxford comma.
- Refer to Chicago institutions, neighborhoods, and cultural figures with familiarity — our readers know the city.

Article Structure

- **Introduction:** Open with a scene, anecdote, or compelling observation. The first paragraph sets the tone for the whole piece.
- **Body:** Develop your subject with reporting, quotes, and detail. Each paragraph should earn its place.
- **Closing:** End on a resonant note — a quote, a reflection, or a look forward. Don't simply summarize.

Headlines

Supply a working headline with your submission. It should be descriptive and specific — avoid vague titles. Your editor may refine it for the site.

Bylines

Your byline will appear as "By [First Name Last Name]" with your title or column name if applicable. Let your editor know if you prefer a variation.

Fact-Checking

You are responsible for the accuracy of facts in your article — names, dates, titles, and quotations. If you are uncertain about a detail, flag it for your editor.

Length Guidelines

- Profiles and features: 600–1,200 words
- Event coverage and reviews: 400–800 words
- Essays and columns: 500–1,000 words
- Short items (DateBook, briefs): 50–150 words

When in doubt, err on the side of concision. A tight 600-word piece is almost always stronger than a meandering 1,000-word one.

3. Submitting Your Article

Send your article as a Microsoft Word (.docx) file to Judy Carmack Bross (judycbross@aol.com) with a copy to John Bartlett (john.bartlett@gmail.com).

Photo Placement Instructions

If you have specific photos to accompany your article, indicate where each photo should appear in the text using a parenthetical note:

(Photo of the gala crowd, caption: Guests at the ICA benefit, March 2026)

Send photos as separate email attachments — do not embed them in the Word document. See the Photo Standards document for full guidelines.

Designating a Cover Photo

If one photo should be used as the article's hero (lead) image, say so clearly in your email: "Cover photo for [Article Title]: [filename]."

Deadlines

Articles for a Sunday edition should be submitted by the prior Wednesday. If you need an extension, contact Judy as early as possible.

4. Working with Your Editor

Judy Carmack Bross reviews all articles before publication. She may return pieces with editorial notes or suggested revisions. Please respond to edits promptly.

Articles marked DRAFT will be treated as works in progress and will not be published until you give the go-ahead.

Once your article is live, you will receive a link to the published page for your records.

Questions? Contact Judy at judycbross@aol.com or John at john.bartlett@gmail.com.